

10 MOST EROTIC ARTWORKS

Art of Life

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The writer is an artist



Ancient Greek ceramics, the ruins of Pompeii, paintings on Paleolithic caves and on our very own Ajanta caves, all stand proof of the fact that art is the oldest form of erotica. Ten of my favourites:

1 GUSTAV KLIMT'S *THE KISS*

I saw this work at the Galerie Belvedere in Vienna a couple of months ago and it remains one of the paintings I've loved since my early days at art school. The painting is brimming with not just love, passion and eroticism but through a careful deployment of Art Nouveau patterning and opulence, manages to mix the image of love with the image of fulfilment, which I think is its key success.

2 AKBAR PADAMSEE'S *THE LOVERS*

Akbar Padamsee's *The Lovers* is a very sensuous image of a man holding the breast of his lover, based on Uma-Maheshwara renditions. The work attracted much debate leading to a court case which the artist finally won. In 1954, Padamsee was arrested for what was one of the earliest debates on censorship and eroticism in the nation's nascent art history. Besides being an accomplished painting, it is also a key work for the dialogue it generated around themes of the erotic in the years immediately after Independence.

3 EDOUARD MANET'S *OLYMPIA*

Edouard Manet's *Olympia* sits completely nude looking at the viewer with a vacant, confrontational gaze while her black maid, fully clothed, attends to her with a bouquet of flowers. Her pale white, idealised body, a black ribbon around her neck and her slippers, which she continues to wear even as she sits on the bed, creates an intense erotic setting that disturbed the academic canon of the time.

4 NOBUYOSHI ARAKI'S NUDE PHOTOGRAPHS

Nobuyoshi Araki's photographs often cross the line of eroticism and enter the terrain of perversion and scandal. Pleasure is mixed with pain, violence, subjugation and bears the scars of exploitation. I include Araki's work in this list mainly because of the dark undertones that exist in his work. The discomfort one feels on seeing the pictures is central to his practice and he has invested a lifetime of work that explores this terrain.

5 AUGUSTE RODIN'S *THE KISS*

Auguste Rodin's *The Kiss* is an image of unadulterated desire and love. Clearly, one of the most-photographed and reproduced art works, it continues to exist in one's imagination as the finest sculptural renditions of a kiss or an embrace.

6 ROBERT MAPPLETHORPE'S *MAN IN POLYESTER SUIT*

The corridors of art history are filled with images of female nudes and celebrations of feminine beauty. However, Mapplethorpe's celebrates masculinity and the patron of male love Eros. *Man in Polyester Suit* is a dramatic image of an exposed penis; the piece effectively mixes homoeroticism with a transgressive spirit that can be seen in most of his other work.

7 JEFF KOONS' *MADE IN HEAVEN*

Jeff Koons created a large body of work depicting him making love to his (ex) wife, the Italian porn star La Cicciolina. While these decadent pictures, playfully bordering on the perverse, were staged in photo studios and their sculptural adaptation fabricated in various production facilities, they are rather audaciously titled *Made in Heaven*.

8 TAKASHI MURAKAMI'S *MY LONESOME COWBOY AND HIROPON*

These two works are in my list not only because of their intrinsic eroticism, but because they are a morph between the rawness of overt sexuality and the playfulness of Japanese manga. *Hiropon* is a whimsical depiction of a big-breasted sex doll whose spilling breast milk becomes her skipping rope; similarly *My Lonesome Cowboy* depicts a boy with an erect penis masturbating with a fountain of sperm in the air.

9 MARINA ABRAMOVIC'S *BALKAN EROTIC EPIC*

Marina Abramovic's multi-channel video installation *Balkan Erotic Epic* explores the definition of sexuality in Balkan pagan traditions. Most of her pioneering work phrases hard questions through the persuasion of beauty and the *Balkan Erotic Epic* is no exception.

10 THE ILLUSTRATIONS OF VATSYAYANA'S *KAMA SUTRA*

Let me finally cast a generic vote for all the anonymous artists who have over the centuries given a visual form to Vatsyayana's *Kama Sutra*.